

Fact, Opinion & Bias Detection — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 60 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITIONS

Fact: a statement that can be checked and proven true or false. **Opinion:** a personal judgement or belief that cannot be proven either way.

TECHNIQUE — THE PROOF TEST

Ask: "could I look this up and confirm it?" If yes, it's a fact. If it depends on someone's personal view (best, worst, should, terrible, wonderful), it's an opinion — even if stated confidently.

BIAS CLUES — COPY THE LIST

- **Loaded language:** emotionally charged words instead of neutral ones (e.g. "slashed" instead of "reduced")
- **One-sided information:** only presenting evidence for one side
- **Unsupported generalisation:** "everyone thinks," "nobody disputes," with no evidence
- **Selective detail:** including facts that support one view, omitting ones that don't

SENTENCE FRAME TO COPY

"This is [a fact/an opinion], because it [can/cannot] be proven. The word '____' shows bias because ____."

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A

The council spent £340,000 on the new playground. It's honestly the best use of public money the town has ever seen.

1. Which sentence is a fact? How do you know?

2. Which sentence is an opinion? How do you know?

3. Identify the loaded/opinion word in the second sentence.

4. Rewrite the second sentence as a neutral, fact-based statement.

5. Apply the Proof Test to explain your answer to Q1.

EXTRACT B

Ever since the factory closed, unemployment in the town has risen by 12%. Naturally, nobody in charge seems to care.

6. Which sentence is a fact, and which is an opinion?

7. Identify the bias clue used in the second sentence (loaded language, one-sided info, generalisation, or selective detail).

8. Why is "nobody in charge seems to care" unproven?

9. What evidence would be needed to support the second sentence as fact?

10. Rewrite the passage removing the bias, keeping only verifiable information.

EXTRACT C

The two candidates disagreed sharply on the new bypass. One local paper only quoted residents who supported it; a second only quoted those against.

11. What bias clue is described here?

12. Why is quoting only one side a problem for a reader trying to form a balanced view?

13. Is the passage itself biased, or is it describing bias in other sources? Explain.

14. What would a balanced report need to include instead?

15. Write a fact and an opinion sentence of your own about a local issue.

EXTRACT D

The new bus route runs every 15 minutes during rush hour. Frankly, it's a pointless waste of a route nobody actually needed.

16. Which sentence is fact, which is opinion?

17. Identify the loaded language in the opinion sentence.

18. Apply the Proof Test to both sentences.

19. What unsupported generalisation is made in the second sentence?

20. Rewrite the second sentence as a fact-based, neutral alternative.

Apply this every time: Whenever a sentence uses a word like "best," "worst," "obviously," "nobody," or "everyone," treat it as a signal to check for opinion or bias before accepting it as fact.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

1. Sentence 1 — a checkable amount spent
2. Sentence 2 — a personal judgement
3. "best"
4. Model neutral rewrite
5. Can be verified via council records
6. 1st = fact, 2nd = opinion

7. Unsupported generalisation ("nobody... seems")
8. No evidence given for what "in charge" think/feel
9. Statements/quotes from officials
10. Model rewrite
11. One-sided information
12. Reader only sees one perspective, can't judge fairly

- 13. Describing bias elsewhere, not necessarily biased itself
- 14. Quotes from both sides
- 15. Model fact + opinion pair
- 16. 1st = fact, 2nd = opinion

- 17. "pointless waste"
- 18. Sentence 1 verifiable; sentence 2 cannot be proven
- 19. "nobody actually needed"
- 20. Model neutral rewrite